



The One With The 90s Thanksgiving

A Cultural Deep Dive into
"Friends" Season 1, Episode 9

Start Lesson

The Post-Cold War "Slacker" Era

The Vibe

Pre-digital optimism, casual hangouts, and irony. Young adults navigating life without cell phones or social media.

The Social Hub

Coffeehouses completely replaced bars as the ultimate place to hang out.

The Archetype

Independent, quirky friends trying to survive in New York City on low-paying jobs.



Turkey Day Basics



The Feast

The traditional dinner features turkey, cranberry sauce, and yams.



Touch Football

A casual, fiercely competitive backyard game played before or after the meal.



The Macy's Parade

A massive morning event featuring giant, 80-foot inflatables floating through the streets of New York City.

Season 1, Episode 9: "The One Where Underdog Gets Away"



It's 1994. Monica volunteers to cook her first Thanksgiving dinner for the gang. Everyone's original holiday plans are ruined, so they celebrate together. But when an 80-foot parade balloon escapes, everyone rushes to the roof—and they get locked out of the apartment while the dinner burns!

OK

Cancel

Everyone's Plans Go Wrong



Rachel:

Goal: Wants to ski in Vail.

Obstacle: Cannot afford the \$100 ticket advance, then misses her flight.



Joey:

Goal: Wants to go home to his family.

Obstacle: His family thinks he has an STD because of a subway health poster he modeled for.



Chandler:

Goal: Wants to boycott the holiday completely.

Obstacle: Traumatized because his parents announced their divorce over Thanksgiving dinner.



Ross:

Goal: Wants to eat his mom's lumpy potatoes.

Obstacle: Depressed about his divorce, spends the day singing to his unborn baby.



Phoebe:

Goal: Wants to celebrate with her grandmother.

Obstacle: Grandma's boyfriend is lunar and celebrates in December.



Monica:

Goal: Wants to host the perfect traditional meal.

Obstacle: Gets locked out; the food turns to charcoal.

The “Key Confusion”

Step 1: The Distraction

Chandler announces the giant Underdog balloon broke free over Washington Square Park.

Step 2: The Question

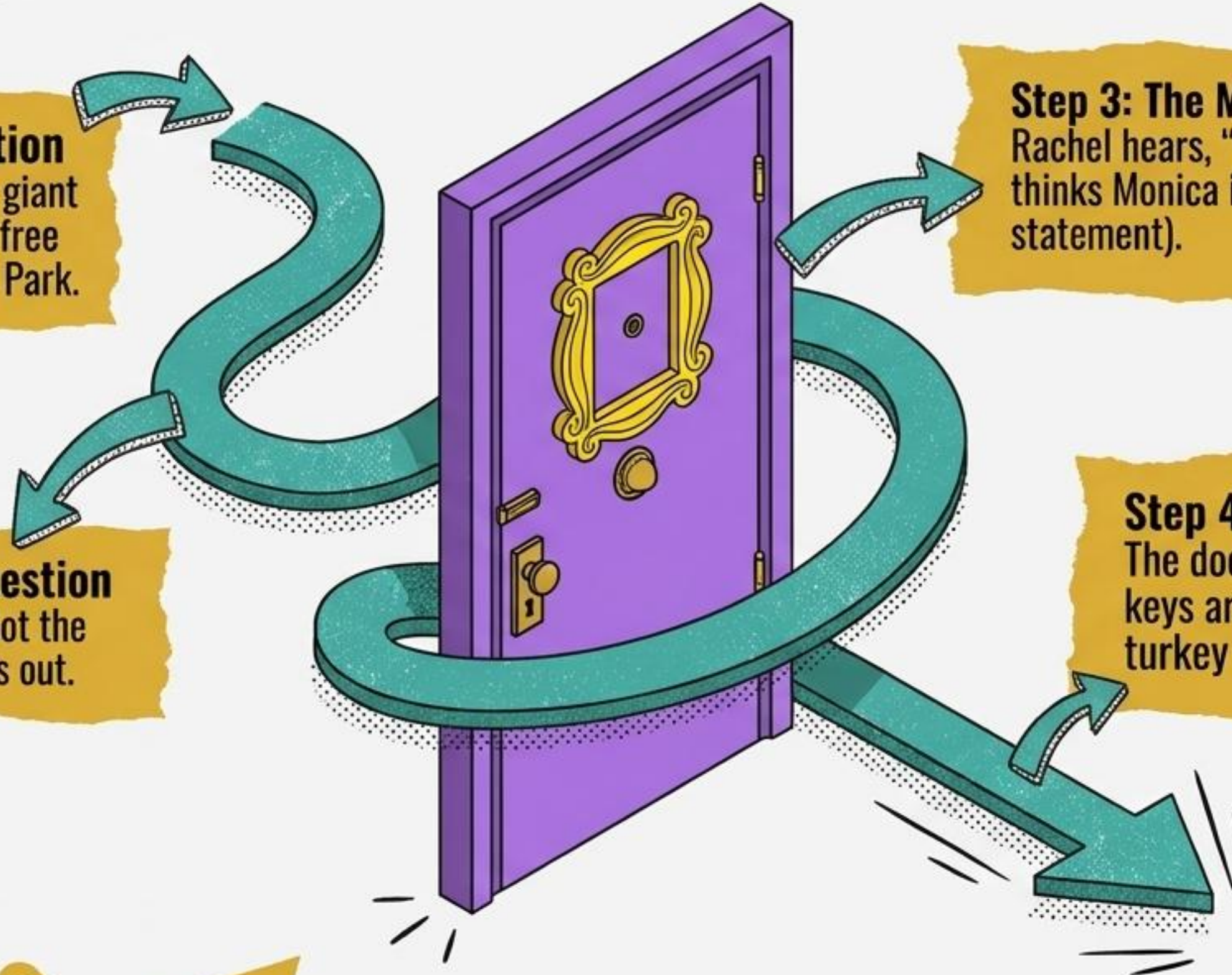
Monica shouts, “Got the keys?” as she runs out.

Step 3: The Misunderstanding

Rachel hears, “Got the keys.” (She thinks Monica is making a statement).

Step 4: The Disaster

The door slams shut. The keys are inside. The turkey burns.



**What Mario
isn't telling you...**



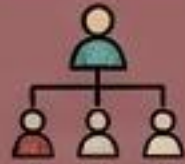
The Fake Poster Trope

- The Setup: Joey takes a job modeling for a city free clinic poster to make money.
- The Joke: New Yorkers—including Joey's own family—cannot tell fiction from reality. They assume he actually has the disease.
- The Result: Joey is uninvited from his family's dinner and forced to eat at Monica's apartment.

The Paradigm Shift: Biological vs. Logical Family

Traditional Holiday Expectations

- Blood relatives only.



- High stress and forced traditions.



- Pretending everything is perfect.



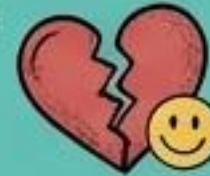
- A perfectly cooked 20lb turkey.



The 90s "Chosen Family" Reality



- Friends acting as family.



- Accepting each other's flaws and failures.



- Shared trauma and honest laughter.



- Burned potatoes and grilled cheese sandwiches.



"I'm very thankful that all of your Thanksgivings sucked." – Chandler Bing

Speak Like a 90s New Yorker

Advance (noun): Getting paid your salary before your normal payday.
(e.g., Rachel asks her boss for a \$100 advance to buy ski tickets).

Boycott (verb): To refuse to participate in something as a protest.
(e.g., Chandler boycotts Thanksgiving).

Vividly (adverb): Remembering something very clearly and in great detail.

Tater Tots (noun): Small, cylindrical pieces of deep-fried, grated potatoes. Joey demands these as a holiday tradition.

Shoop (slang/onomatopoeia): The sound Rachel makes to imitate skiing down a mountain.



The Ultimate Fallback Plan

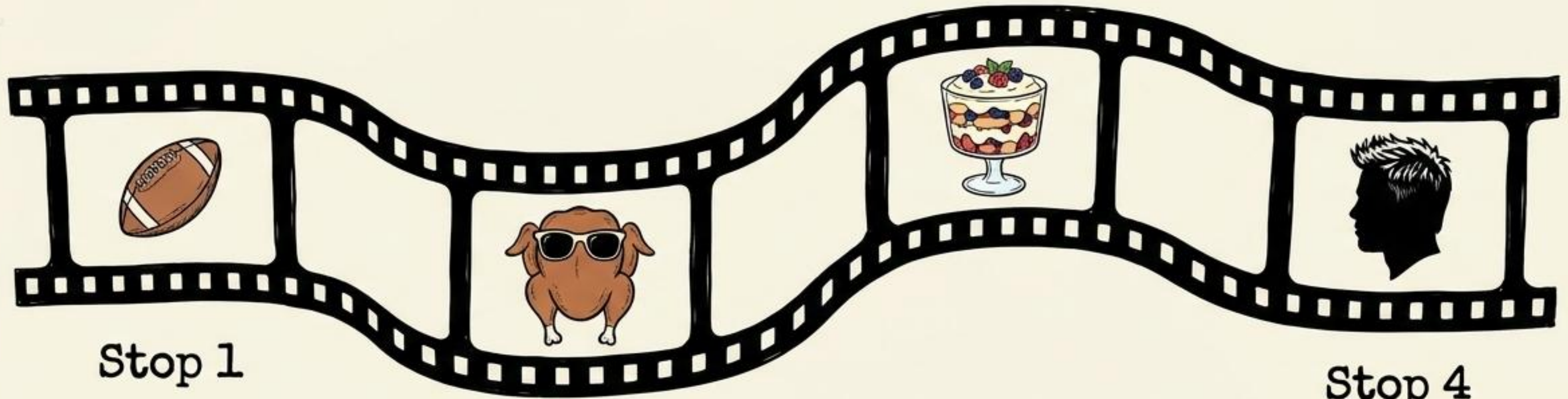
When Monica's perfectly planned, three-potato feast turns to charcoal, Chandler's boycott meal saves the day.



The episode proves that the food doesn't matter; the company does. They raise their sandwiches to toast to a "lousy Christmas and a crappy New Year."

A Decade of "Crappy Holidays"

Season 1 proved that ruined holidays make the best television.



Stop 1

Season 3: The intense sibling rivalry in "The Football Game."

Stop 2

Season 5: The flashbacks and the "Turkey on the Head."

Stop 3

Season 6: Rachel accidentally puts beef in the English Trifle.

Stop 4

Season 8: The high school rumor and the Brad Pitt cameo.

LEVEL 1: True or False?

1. Rachel successfully flew to Vail, Colorado to go skiing. [T / F]

2. Chandler loves Thanksgiving because he has great childhood memories. [T / F]

3. Joey's family uninvited him to dinner because they saw a public health poster.
[T / F]

1. F, 2. F, 3. T

A silver vintage microphone with a paperclip attached to its top, emitting two yellow lightning bolts.

LEVEL 2: Short Answer

Q1: What specific event caused everyone to abandon the apartment and run up to the roof?

Q2: Because everyone had different demands, what vegetable did Monica have to prepare three different ways?

Q3: What exact food did the friends eat for dinner after the original meal burned in the oven?

Over to You! (Class Discussion)

Have you ever experienced a holiday dinner or family event that went completely wrong? What happened?

The show popularized the idea of a "chosen family." Do you think friends can be just as important as biological relatives?

If you were locked out and your holiday meal burned, what is your ultimate "fallback" comfort food?



Thanks for hanging out!



Class dismissed. Grab a coffee!